

OVERVIEW

The escalation of hostilities across the Middle East and beyond has triggered a humanitarian crisis spanning multiple regions in an already fragile context, **with significant impact to population mobility**. National social systems and host community safety networks are under considerable strain as protection needs continue to rise. The temporary cessation of hostilities remains fragile and subject to change, requiring continued monitoring and operational readiness while the humanitarian consequences of earlier hostilities continue to affect populations across multiple regions.

In the Islamic Republic of Iran, widespread destruction of more than 149,000 civilian infrastructures and essential services,¹ including hospitals, schools and emergency facilities, continues to reduce basic living conditions. As of 29 April 2026, an estimated 400,000 people have seen their homes directly affected by housing damages. Mobility patterns are being shaped by housing damage, livelihood loss, and service disruptions, leading to temporary internal relocation, reliance on family networks, and increased labour related movement. While no large scale cross border displacement has been observed, the cumulative pressures are contributing to heightened interest in outward migration among vulnerable groups, including youth, migrants, and low income urban households. Overall, population movements remain localised, temporary, and economically driven, with no signs of mass displacement; however, ongoing strain on housing, livelihoods, and basic services is likely to sustain elevated mobility levels in the near- and medium-term.

In Lebanon, despite the announcement of a new 45-day ceasefire on 15 May, hostilities persist. As security conditions worsens, displacement remains severe, with over one million internally displaced persons (IDPs) reported,² including 129,721 IDPs accommodated across 632 collective sites³ though a majority remain outside formal sites. Geographic distribution of displacement is uneven – areas such as Beirut, Mount Lebanon and North Lebanon are experiencing mounting pressure from successive waves of displacement, while returns remain limited due to insecurity, damaged housing, lack of services, and risks associated with unexploded ordnance. Collective sites and host communities face sustained pressure as some previously displaced families return to shelters after unsuccessful attempts to return home. Cross-border flows into the Syrian Arab Republic are continuing, with a total of 333,856 movements recorded as of 18 May 2026,⁴ placing additional pressure on an already overstretched humanitarian system.

IOM's Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) is on the ground, actively tracking displacement and cross-border mobility while scaling operations in coordination with local authorities and partners to better understand how the crisis is impacting human mobility in the region.

1 Source: Iranian Red Crescent Society, April 2026.
2 United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, (May, 2026). Lebanon: Flash Update #23 – Escalation of hostilities in Lebanon (as of 4 May 2026).
3 Source: Lebanon Disaster Risk Management Unit, May 2026.
4 Cross-border figure into the Syrian Arab Republic are now sourced from DTM Syria, in coordination with border authorities in the country as of 18 May 2026 while cross-border figure into Lebanon are from Lebanon Border Control Committee (BCC), in collaboration with the General Directorate of General Security (GSD) and the Land Border Regiments), as of 20 April 2026. Please note that due to variations in population coverage, sources and methodology, official sources on movements between Lebanon and Syrian Arab Republic may differ.
5 Cumulative flow data from the Islamic Republic of Iran to both Afghanistan and Pakistan are reported for the period from 01 March to 18 May 2026. Data for movements between the Islamic Republic of Iran and Iraq are available between 01 and 30 April 2026 for 4 out of 12 BCPs. Lebanon–Syrian Arab Republic figures are reported separately for 02 March to 30 April 2026. Sources include DTM, the Lebanon Border Control Committee (BCC) and General Security Directorate (GSD), the Iraq Border Point Commission, and Pakistani authorities. Increases and decreases noted below are week to week changes.
6 These PoEs represent a subset of the 43 official land PoEs located along the borders of the Islamic Republic of Iran, the Syrian Arab Republic, and Lebanon.
7. This BCP is located on the Syrian Arab Republic side of the border with Lebanon.



INTERNAL DISPLACEMENT

AS OF 14 MAY 2026, THERE WERE 129,721 IDPs REPORTED IN 632 COLLECTIVE SITES
Source: Lebanon Disaster Risk Management Unit, May 2026



MIXED POPULATION MOVEMENTS⁵

since 01 March

333,856	LEBANON —> SYRIAN ARAB REPUBLIC
358,496	THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN —> AFGHANISTAN ▼ -2% since the last reporting period (05-11 May)
22,673	THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN —> PAKISTAN ▲ +11% since the last reporting period (05-11 May)
271,751	THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN —> IRAQ (4 out of 12 BCPs) No update since 30 April
141,023	AFGHANISTAN —> THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN ▲ +1% since the last reporting period (05-11 May)
270,142	IRAQ (4 out of 12 BCPs) —> THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN No update since 30 April



POINTS OF ENTRY (PoEs)⁶

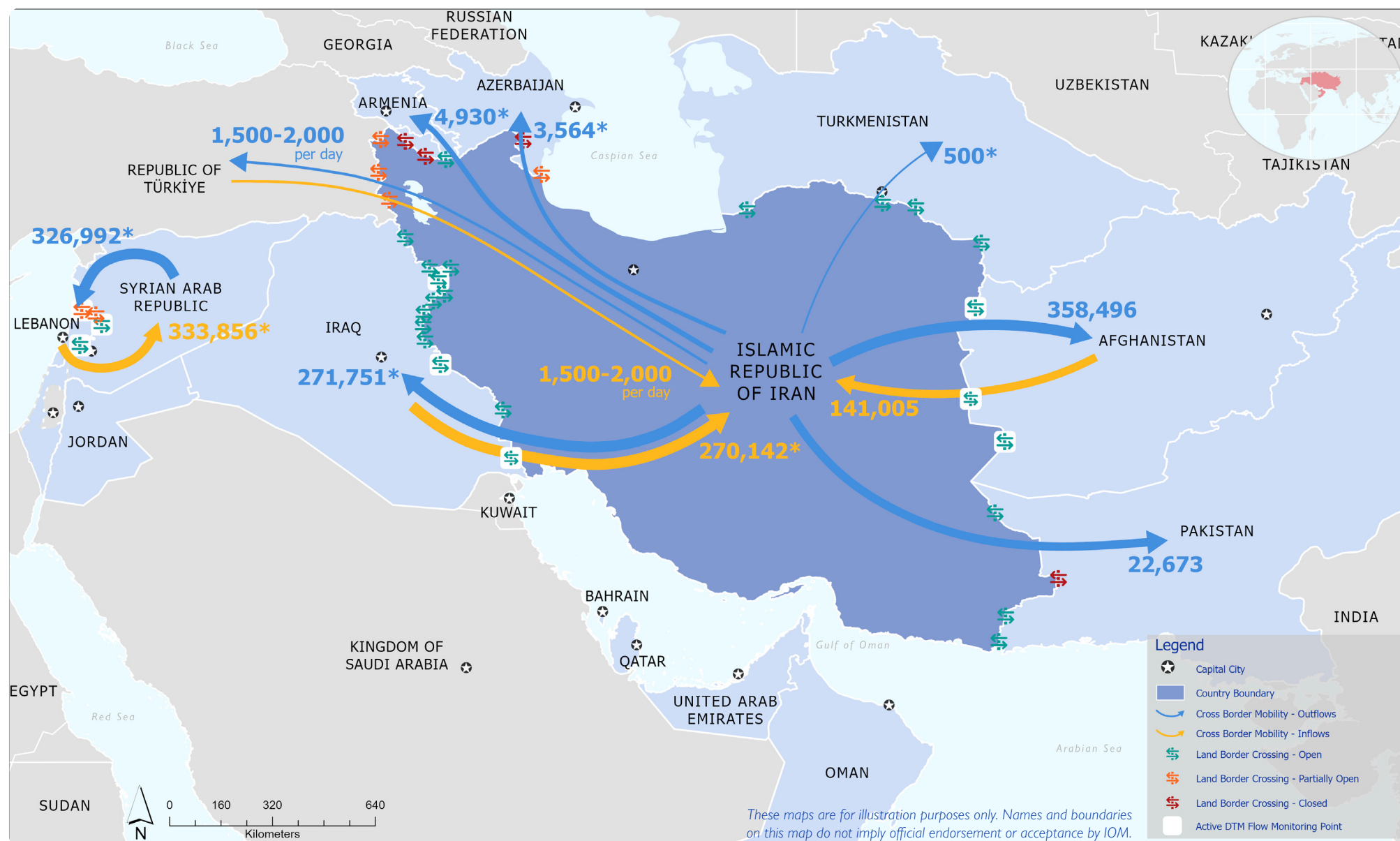
An additional PoE was partially opened during this reporting period: Jisr- Al Qamar BCP.⁷

30 PoEs ARE FULLY OPEN	8 PoEs ARE PARTIALLY OPEN	5 PoEs ARE CLOSED
✓ 7 of which are actively conducting DTM flow monitoring	✓ 1 of which is actively conducting DTM flow monitoring	

ESCALATION IN THE MIDDLE EAST AND BEYOND — MOBILITY REPORT

Data collection period: 12 - 18 May 2026 | Publication date: 21 May 2026

Map 1. Mixed population movements surrounding the Islamic Republic of Iran, as of 18 May 2026



* Note: Figures for Turkmenistan are current as of 19 March 2026; for Armenia, they cover the period from 28 February to 10 March 2026; for Azerbaijan, from 28 February to 29 April 2026; for Iraq, from 01 to 30 April 2026 (for 4 out of 12 BCPs); Cross-border figure into the Syrian Arab Republic are now sourced from DTM Syria, in coordination with border authorities in the country as of 18 May 2026 while cross-border figure into Lebanon are from Lebanon Border Control Committee (BCC), in collaboration with the General Directorate of General Security (GSD) and the Land Border Regiments, as of 20 April 2026. Please note that due to variations in population coverage, sources and methodology, official sources on movements between Lebanon and Syrian Arab Republic may differ.

IMPACT ON NEIGHBOURING COUNTRIES OF THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN

The conflict is affecting mobility along shared borders between the Islamic Republic of Iran and its neighbouring countries, driving reactive movements and precautionary travel within and across borders.

Since the start of the crisis, **flows from the Islamic Republic of Iran to neighbouring countries have fluctuated over time, varying significantly between countries.** Afghanistan receives the highest number of movements with substantial dips and spikes while Pakistan and Iraq see much smaller and more occasional movements. Overall, cross-border flows remain moderate and variable rather than steadily increasing.

AFGHANISTAN

Between 01 March and 18 May 2026, a total of 358,496 individuals entered Afghanistan from the Islamic Republic of Iran, corresponding to a daily average of 4,538 movements, while 141,023 individuals departed Afghanistan to the Islamic Republic of Iran over the same reporting period (1,785 daily average).

During the reporting period of 12-18 May 2026, cross-border movements along the Afghanistan–Islamic Republic of Iran border at Milak, Islam Qala, and Abu Nasr Farahi border crossing points (BCPs) remained stable, with all three BCPs fully operational and no disruptions reported.

Both inflows from the Islamic Republic of Iran to Afghanistan and outflows from Afghanistan to the Islamic Republic of Iran continued at a consistent level, in line with the trend observed during the previous week.

Inflows continued to be shaped by a mix of forced and voluntary returns with forced returns outweighing

spontaneous returns. Reported drivers included police harassment, limited livelihood opportunities, and rising living costs in the Islamic Republic of Iran. This is particularly notable among inflows recorded at Malik BCP, with a higher volume of voluntary returns by Afghan passport holders with Iranian visas returning. This is reportedly due to unpaid wages, limited employment opportunities, approaching Eid celebration in the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Analysis of Flow Monitoring Survey (FMS) found that from 12 to 18 May 2026, outflows of Iranian nationals were predominantly recorded via Islam Qala–Taybad, with intended destinations concentrated in Sistan and Baluchestan (approximately 35%), Razavi Khorasan (23%), and Tehran (16%). The main drivers reported for leaving the previous country prior to transiting Afghanistan included family reunification in the Islamic Republic of Iran (around 40%), security concerns (34%), and visa expiry or non-renewal (28%). Nearly all respondents (approximately 99%) cited family, relatives, or social networks in the Islamic Republic of Iran as the primary reason for selecting their destination.

In contrast, inflows of Iranian nationals from the Islamic Republic of Iran into Afghanistan were overwhelmingly recorded via Islam Qala–Taybad (approximately 96%), with final destinations mainly in Herat (48%), followed by Kabul (13%) and Balkh (9%). These movements were predominantly individual-based (approximately 89% traveling alone) and short-term, with 83% intending to stay less than one month. Reported motivations were largely economic or temporary in nature. Meanwhile, return movements of Afghan nationals continue to reflect ongoing economic hardship and protection pressures within the Islamic Republic of Iran, reinforcing sustained mixed and circular mobility dynamics across the border.

Figure 1. Daily number of flows of Iranian nationals between the Islamic Republic of Iran and Afghanistan (01 April to 18 May 2026)

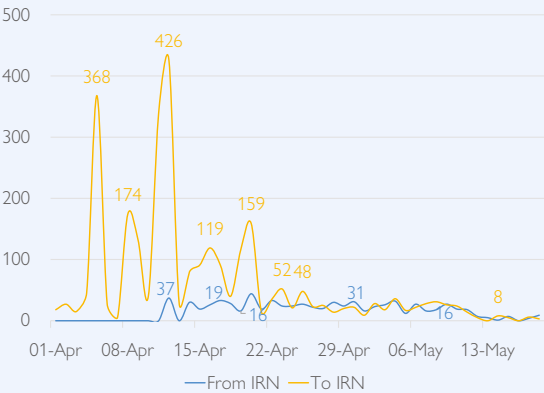
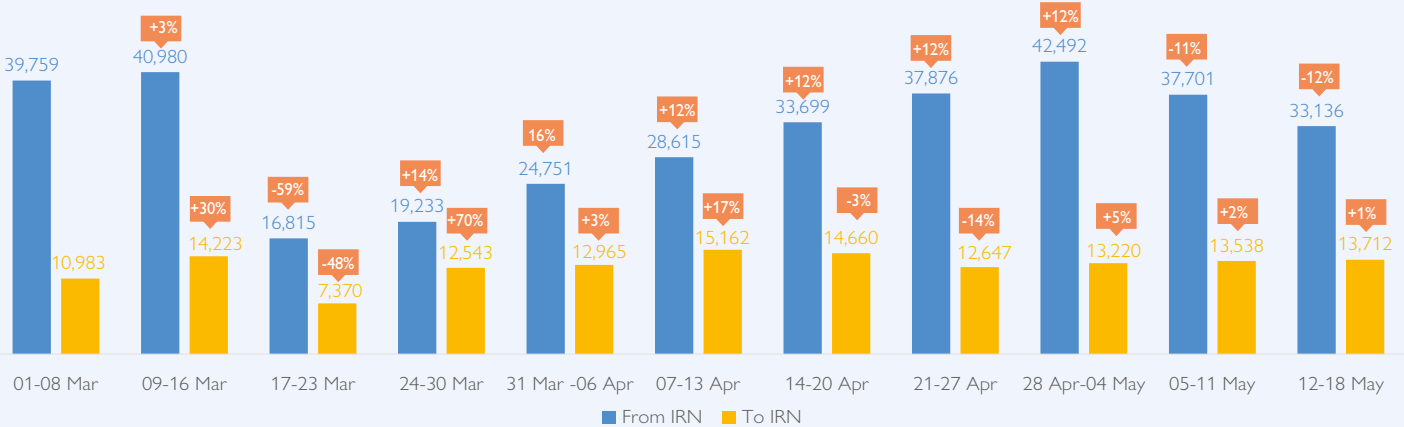


Figure 2. Weekly number of total flows between the Islamic Republic of Iran and Afghanistan (01 March to 18 May 2026)



PAKISTAN

Between 01 March and 18 May 2026, a total of 22,673 individuals crossed from the Islamic Republic of Iran into Pakistan, representing a daily average of 287 flows. Movements occurred primarily through the Taftan–Mirjaveh crossing (19,222 individuals) and the Gabd–Kumb–Rimdan crossing 3,451 individuals).⁸

Cross-border movement from the Islamic Republic of Iran to Pakistan through the Gabd and Taftan BCPs remains restricted. Currently, only students, drivers, pilgrims, and tourists with valid passports and visas are permitted entry.

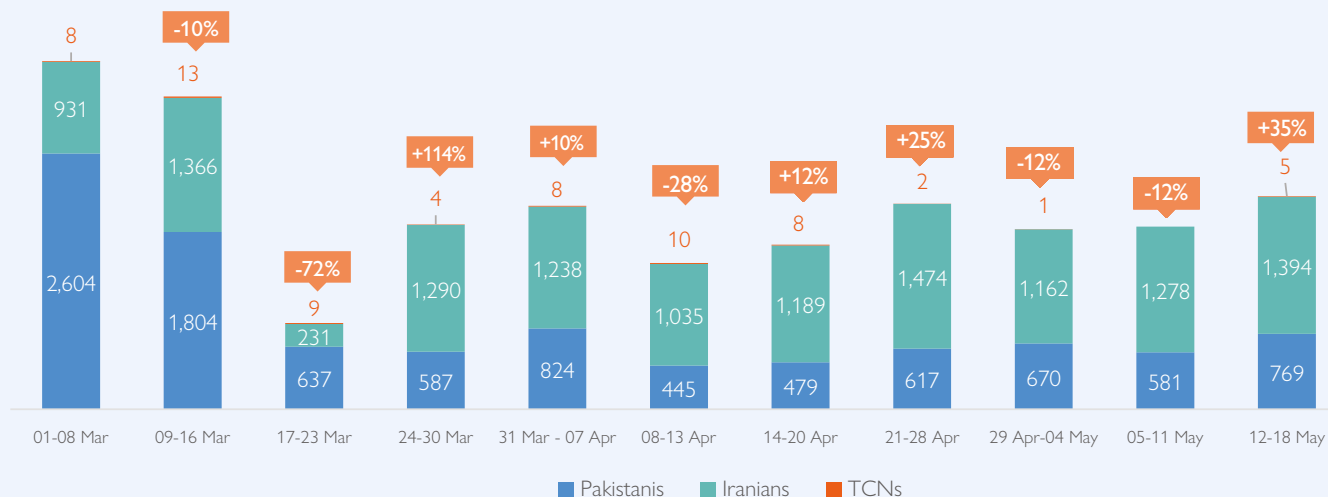
Many travellers are using Pakistan solely as a transit route due to the closure of Iranian airports amid the conflict, before continuing to onward destinations. Those traveling irregularly to the Islamic Republic of Iran are detained by Iranian authorities and handed over to Pakistan's Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) for processing.

Border authorities reported no influx of Iranian nationals other than those with valid passports and visas in Pakistan. The majority of Iranian arrivals subsequently returned to the Islamic Republic of Iran, primarily as their visits were trade-related.

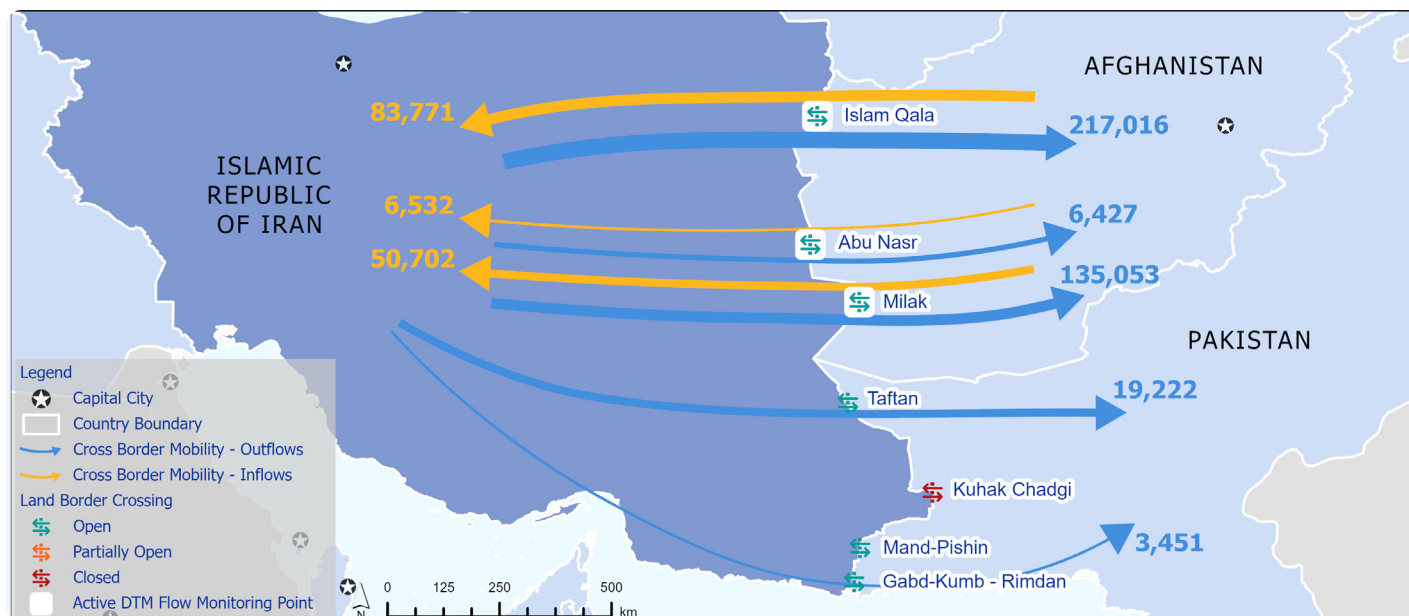
Outbound movement from Pakistan to the Islamic Republic of Iran continues on a limited basis, restricted to Pakistani students and drivers. Although many students initially returned to Pakistan at the onset of the conflict, some are now traveling back to the Islamic Republic of Iran to resume studies.

As of 18 May 2026, a total of 68 Third Country Nationals (TCNs) were recorded in Pakistan. According to authorities, TCNs entering through the Taftan and Gabd–Rimdan borders were mostly tourists or businessmen. Many had been stranded in the Islamic Republic of Iran and, due to the unavailability of flights, transited through Pakistan before returning to their countries of origin.

Figure 3. Number of flows from the Islamic Republic of Iran into Pakistan by nationality (01 March to 18 May 2026)



Map 2. Mixed Population Movements between the Islamic Republic of Iran, Afghanistan and Pakistan (as of 18 May)



⁸ Source: Pakistani authorities, May 2026.

IRAQ

CROSS-BORDER MOVEMENT

While no new movement data was received during the current reporting period (12 -18 May 2026), the most recent official figures from the Iraqi Border Point Commission, covering the period between 01 and 30 April 2026, recorded a total of 271,751 individuals entering Iraq from the Islamic Republic of Iran, while 270,142 departed, resulting in a net incoming movements of 1,609 individuals.

As of 18 May 2026, border conditions remained broadly stable compared with the previous reporting period (week ending 11 May 2026), with all crossing points open and no significant restrictions observed.

Despite the resumption of regular operations, Key Informants (KIs) reported that travel volumes have not yet returned to pre-escalation levels. Flows during this reporting week largely mirrored those of the previous week, with notable upticks recorded at Hajj Omran and Zurbatiyah. Hajj Omran BCP has reportedly nearly approached near-full operating conditions: Students are returning to universities in the Islamic Republic of Iran, medical travel is picking up, and commercial activity is regaining momentum.

No BCPs reported emergency response or security incidents during the reporting period.

DTM FLOW MONITORING ACTIVITIES AT KEY BORDER CROSSING POINTS (BCPs)

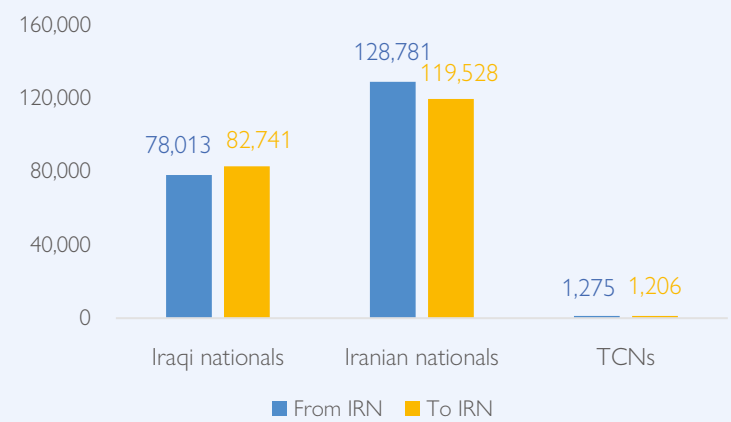
Between 12 and 18 May 2026, Flow Monitoring access remained restricted to Bashmagh, where DTM teams recorded 2,072 incoming and 2,084 outgoing movements, a 47 per cent rise in incoming movements and a 12 per cent drop in outgoing movements compared with the previous reporting week.

Iranian nationals dominated both directions, accounting for 74 per cent of incoming movements and 73 per cent of outgoing movements, with no movements of other Third Country Nationals (TCNs) recorded through the crossing.

Incoming movements of Iranian nationals were driven primarily by family visits (43%), employment (33%), and tourism (12%), with no movements reported as conflict or insecurity-related during the period.

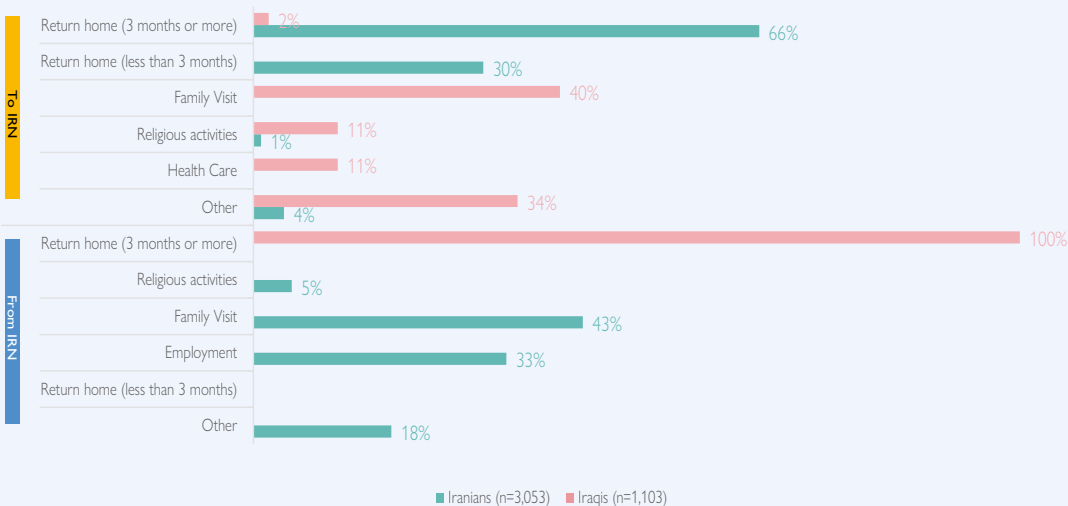
Outgoing movements largely reflected returns to the Islamic Republic of Iran following long-term stays of three months or more (66%) or short-term stays of less than three months (30%).

Figure 4. Total number of flows between the Islamic Republic of Iran and Iraq by nationality (01 and 30 April 2026)



Note: This figure excludes data from Zurbatiyah BCP and reflects aggregated movements recorded at Muntheriyah, Al-Sheeb, and Al Shalamcha only.

Figure 5. Top reasons for cross-border movement into and out of Iraq, among respondents from DTM Iraq's FM activities during the reporting period (12-18 May 2026) (n=4,156)



9 Please note that these figures represent only 4 of the 12 BCPs for which data is currently available: Muntheriyah, Al Sheeb, Al Shalamcha, and Zurbatiyah.

ARMENIA

No new data on movements was received during this reporting period (12-18 May 2026).

Between 28 February and 10 March 2026, a total of 4,930 individuals entered Armenia through the Agarak BCP, including 4,381 Iranian nationals. The main nationalities of TCNs included the Russian Federation (72), the People's Republic of China (61), Kazakhstan (43), and Germany (38). As of 01 April, 1,262 Iranian nationals were reported to have returned to the Islamic Republic of Iran via Armenia from the United Arab Emirates.

Overall, flows of TCNs follows regular mobility patterns, with no sustained abnormal increases observed.

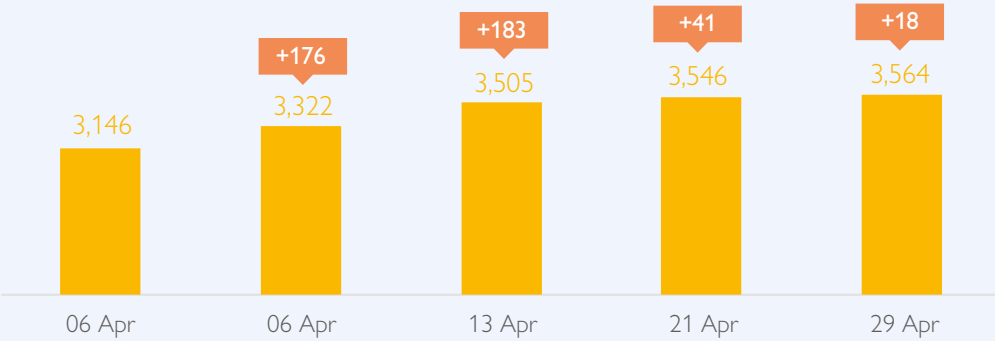
AZERBAIJAN

No new data on movements was received during this reporting period (05 -11 May 2026).

Between 28 February and 29 April 2026, a total of 3,564 individuals crossed from the Islamic Republic of Iran into Azerbaijan via the Astara border crossing, including 622 Azerbaijani nationals. Other top nationalities included People's Republic of China (742), the Russian Federation (397), India (294) and Bangladesh (198).

Overall, flows at the border between Azerbaijan and the Islamic Republic of Iran remain stable, with no indications of large-scale or mass crossings.

Figure 6. Cumulative number of flows by week from the Islamic Republic of Iran to Azerbaijan (As of 29 April 2026)



10 The reporting period for these figures was not specified.



REPUBLIC OF TÜRKİYE

No new data on movements was received during this reporting period (12–18 May 2026).

As of 18 May, the situation along the Republic of Türkiye's border with the Islamic Republic of Iran remains calm, with no indications of irregular movements or increased pressure. Turkish authorities during this period signalled a continued focus on maintaining regional stability and supporting diplomatic efforts to reduce tensions in the wider region.

TURKMENISTAN

No new data on movements was received during this reporting period (12–18 May 2026).

As of 06 May, Uzbekistan organized the return of 41 Uzbek citizens from the Islamic Republic of Iran through Turkmenistan. This is in addition to 13 Uzbek citizens evacuated earlier through Turkmenistan.

According to the EU Delegation in Turkmenistan, additional evacuations of TCNs have taken place. These reportedly included one citizen each from Finland, Austria, Sweden, and France, as well as two citizens from the Netherlands.

IMPACT BEYOND THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN

The escalation of hostilities is affecting mobility well beyond the borders of the Islamic Republic of Iran, with the widening conflict influencing movement patterns across multiple regions.

LEBANON

CROSS-BORDER MOVEMENT

No new data on cross-border movements was received during this reporting period (12 - 18 May 2026).

Between 02 March and 20 April 2026, there were 326,992 individuals crossing from the Syrian Arab Republic into Lebanon.¹¹ The majority of those crossing were Syrian nationals (80%), followed by Lebanese (17%) and other nationalities (3%).

INTERNAL DISPLACEMENT

Since 02 March 2026, hostilities across Lebanon have continued to intensify, prompting population movements in response to growing insecurity, widespread damage to infrastructure, and overstretched welfare services.

The humanitarian situation is deteriorating rapidly, triggering large scale and repeated displacement, as well as onward movements with little notice.

On 15 May, a new 45-day ceasefire extension was announced; however, hostilities persisted, with continued strikes reported across southern Lebanon governorates. Following the deterioration in security conditions, displacement remain high, with over one million internally displaced persons (IDPs) reported,¹³ **including 129,721 IDPs accommodated across 632 collective sites though a majority remain outside formal sites.**¹² **This represents a 7 per cent increase compared to the previous week, when 121,701 IDPs were recorded in collective sites.** Geographic distribution of displacement is uneven with areas such as Beirut, Mount Lebanon and North Lebanon are experiencing mounting pressure from successive waves of displacement, while returns remain limited due to insecurity, damaged housing, lack of services, and risks associated with unexploded ordnance.¹⁴

11 Source: Lebanon Border Control Committee (BCC), in collaboration with the General Directorate of General Security (GSD) and the Land Border Regiments).

12 United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, (May, 2026). Lebanon: Flash Update #23 – Escalation of hostilities in Lebanon (as of 4 May 2026).

13 Source: Lebanon Disaster Risk Management Unit, May 2026.

14 United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, (May, 2026). Lebanon: Flash Update #27 – Escalation of hostilities in Lebanon (as of 18 May 2026)

Figure 7. Weekly number of individuals crossing from Lebanon to the Syrian Arab Republic by nationality (02 March to 20 April 2026)

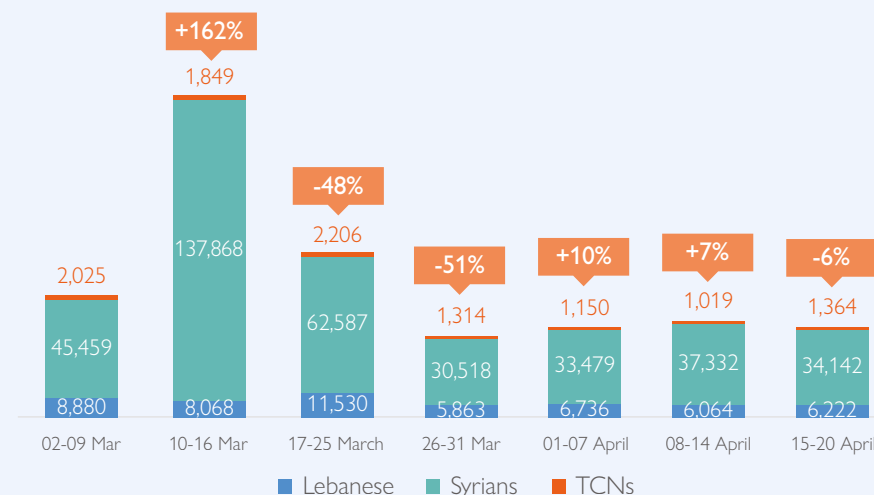
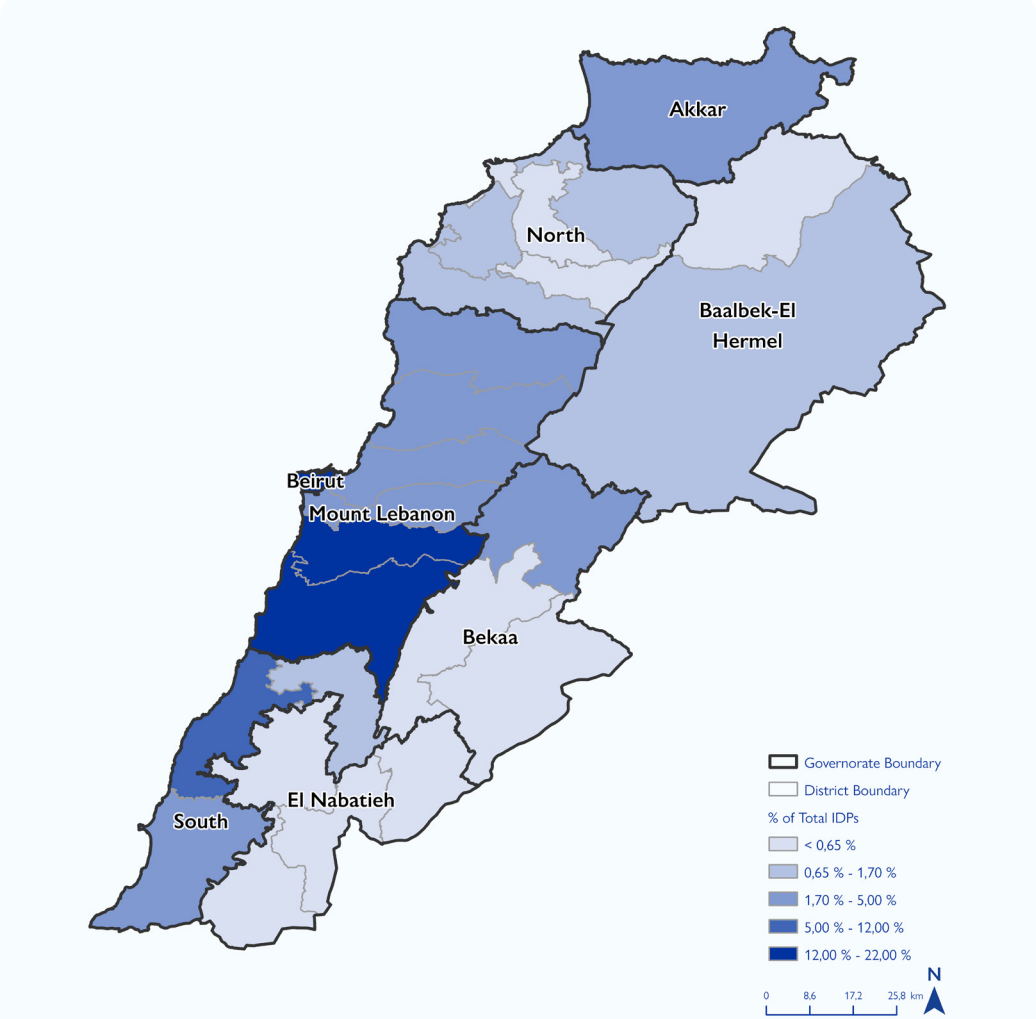


Figure 8. Weekly number of IDPs in collective sites in Lebanon (02 March to 18 May 2026)

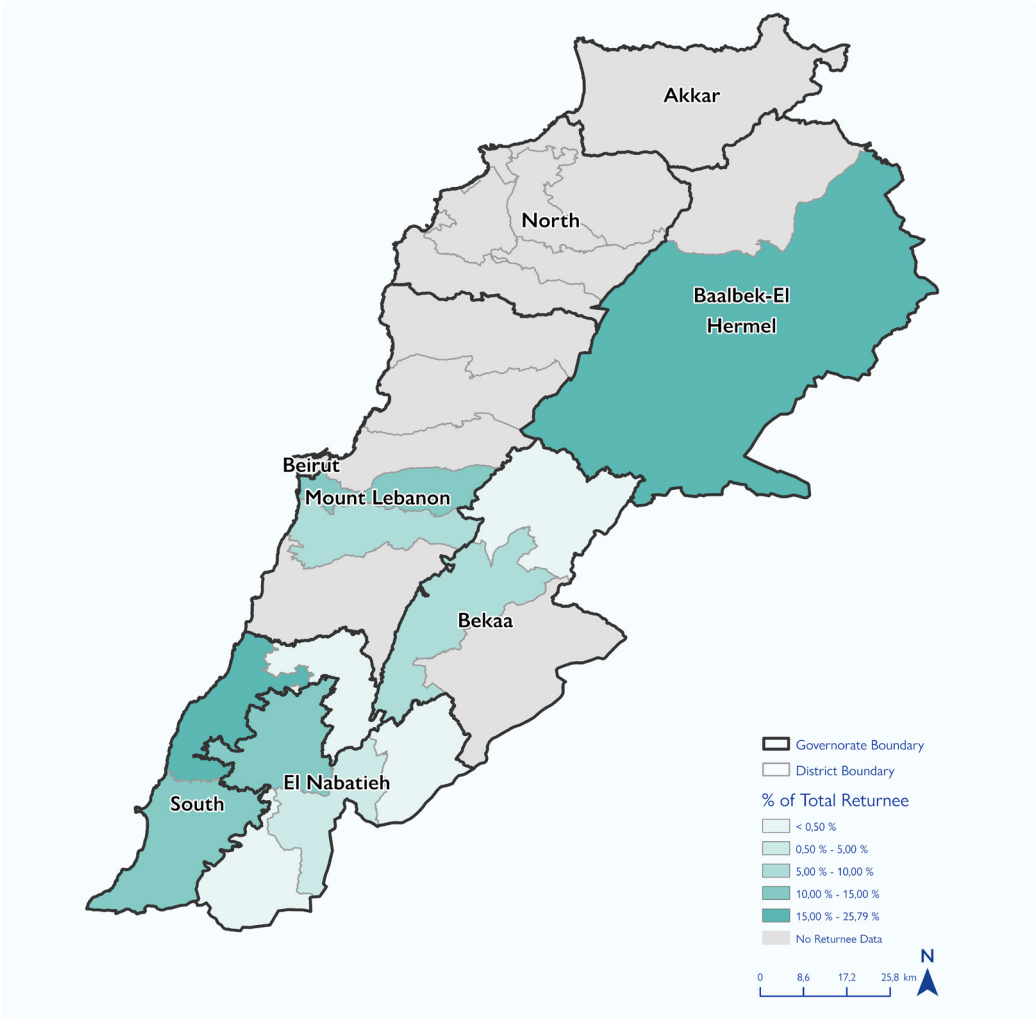


LEBANON

Map 3. Proportion of Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) in Lebanon
(as of 11 May 2026)



Map 4. Proportion of Internally Displaced Person (IDP) Returnees in Lebanon
(as of 11 May 2026)



These maps are for illustration purposes only. Names and boundaries on this map do not imply official endorsement or acceptance by IOM.

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SYRIAN ARAB REPUBLIC

As of 18 May, a total of 333,856 movements had been recorded along the four points of entry (PoEs) at the Syrian- Lebanese border where DTM Syria tracks population movements into the Syrian Arab Republic. Most movements recorded involved Syrian nationals (96%), with Lebanese nationals accounting for the remaining 4 per cent.

In addition to cross-border movements into the Syrian Arab Republic, DTM Syria implemented Emergency Mobility Tracking (EMT) to capture arrivals into the country. Between 02 March and 18 May 2026, DTM Syria recorded 122,083 individuals arriving across 1,230 locations in all 14 governorates in the Syria Arab Republic. Those recorded at arrival locations were predominantly Syrian nationals (99%), with Lebanese nationals accounting for less than 1 per cent.

Between the 12 – 18 May 2026, Key informants (KIs) reported that arriving returnees continue to face multiple reintegration challenges. Access to safe housing remains a primary concern, with many residing in damaged or partially destroyed homes, unfinished buildings, temporary shelters, or low-quality rented accommodation.

Children’s educational integration continues to pose challenges, especially for those who have already been enrolled in Lebanese curriculum, resulting in difficulty adapting to the Syrian education system.

Additionally, livelihoods remain precarious and overwhelmingly informal, leaving returnees largely dependent on seasonal agricultural work and low-paid daily labour, and few find employment commensurate with their prior experiences and skills. A saturated labour market, compounded by weak demands for workers has driven wages down and heightened exposure to exploitative employment practices.

Most arrivals were adult men (31%), followed by adult women (25%), girls (22%), and boys (21%).¹⁵ A distribution that likely reflects employment-related drivers, including both access to livelihoods and job losses. Among the arrivals currently employed (44% of locations), the majority relied on daily wage labour (79%), followed by salaried work (39%) and agriculture or livestock activities (39%). Notably, most KIs considered available income to be inadequate, with 52 per cent reporting it was not sufficient at all to meet basic needs and 46 per cent indicating it was only partially sufficient.

Such insufficient, unstable, and short-term income sources may push individuals to adopt negative coping strategies to meet basic needs, while also contributing to risks of secondary displacement. The continued reliance of some employed arrivals on remittances (18%) and humanitarian assistance (4%) further underscores that income alone is not sufficient to achieve financial stability.

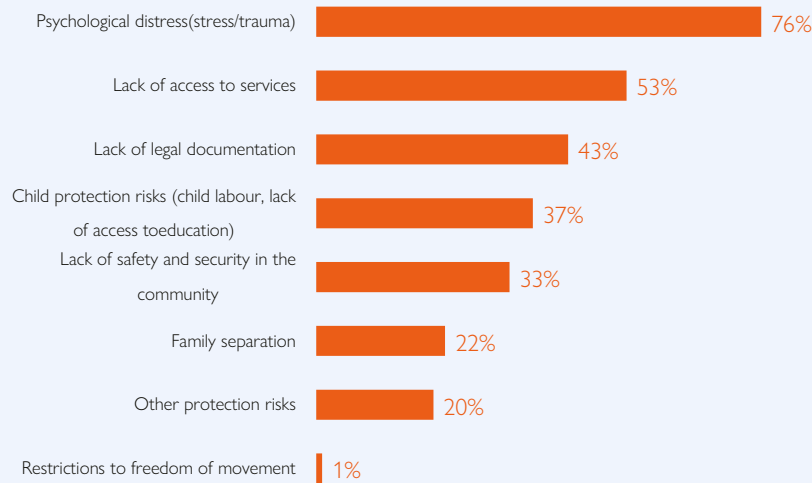
Challenges

Thirty-four per cent of KIs identified significant challenges affecting returnee population (up from 32% in Round 10, indicative of a worsening situation for the returnee population).

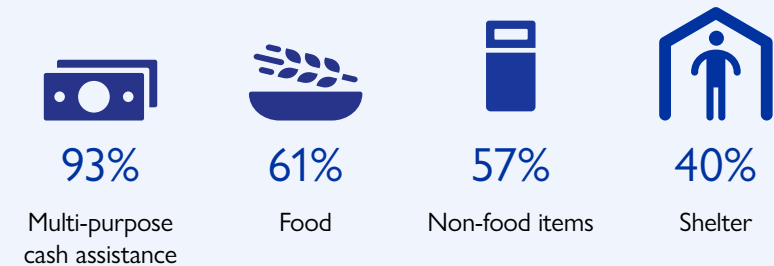
Psychosocial distress was the most frequently reported issue (76%), largely linked to financial hardship, limited employment opportunities, and rising living costs. Barriers to accessing essential services were reported by 53 per cent of KIs, while 43 per cent highlighted challenges related to lost or damaged legal documentation (Please see Figure 9 for further breakdown).

Protection risks were most pronounced in Al-Hasakeh (100%), followed by As-Sweida (79%) and Rural Damascus (61%).

Figure 9. Top reported perceived issues and risks faced (% of arrival locations, multiple answers possible)

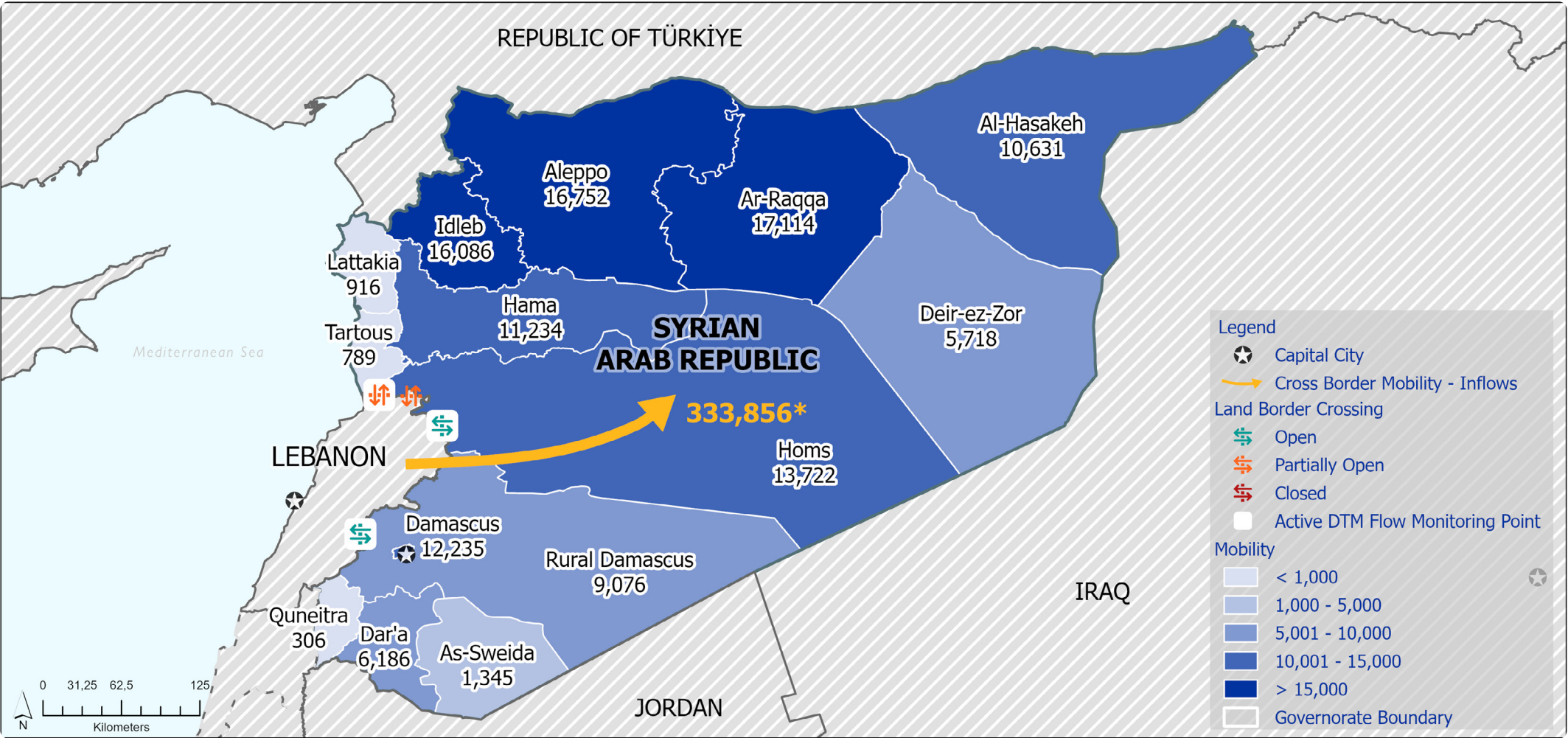


Top reported needs (% of arrival locations, multiple answers possible)



15 Sum of percentages adds up to less 100% due to rounding.

Map 5. Number of Syrian individuals at arrival locations in Syrian Arab Republic (02 March to 18 May 2026)



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* Cross-border figure into the Syrian Arab Republic are now sourced from DTM Syria, in coordination with border authorities in the country as of 18 May 2026 while cross-border figure into Lebanon are from Lebanon Border Control Committee (BCC), in collaboration with the General Directorate of General Security (GSD) and the Land Border Regiments), as of 20 April 2026. Please note that due to variations in population coverage, sources and methodology, official sources on movements between Lebanon and Syrian Arab Republic may differ.

METHODOLOGY

This analysis is based on information compiled weekly from IOM's country offices. DTM monitors population mobility and displacement dynamics across countries in Afghanistan, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Iraq, Lebanon, Pakistan, the Republic of Türkiye, Turkmenistan, and the Syrian Arab Republic.

Data is drawn from primary DTM flow monitoring and mobility tracking activities, alongside secondary sources, such as government data, with all secondary information validated by our field teams. This includes data on cross-border movements, internal displacement, and qualitative insights on emerging mobility trends and humanitarian needs. While efforts are made to align reporting to the same reference week, collection periods may vary across countries.

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